CHAPTER 9

COLONIALISM AND THE COUNTRYSIDE

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master British revenue policies in rural India: Permanent Settlement in Bengal (1793), Zamindari auction auctions, the Hoe and the Plough conflict (Paharias vs Santhals in Rajmahal), and the 1875 Deccan Riots against moneylenders.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Permanent Settlement of Bengal (1793):** Introduced by Lord Cornwallis; fixed land revenue permanently with Zamindars categorized as landowners; failure to pay by sunset of due date (Sunset Law) led to public auction of estates.

• **Rise of the Jotedars:** Wealthy rich ryots (Jotedars and haoladars) acquired thousands of acres in northern Bengal, controlled local moneylending and grain trade, and deliberately undermined Zamindars.

• **The Battle of the Hoe and the Plough:** In the Rajmahal hills, British authorities attempted to settle pastoral shifting Paharias (who used the hoe); settled them by introducing migrant Santhals (who used the plough) in Damin-i Koh; sparked the 1855-56 Santhal Rebellion under Sidhu and Kanhu.

• **Ryotwari System and Deccan Riots (1875):** In Bombay Deccan, revenue was assessed directly on cultivators (Ryots); agricultural price collapses in the 1860s drove ryots into the clutches of Marwari and Gujarati sahukars; erupted in May 1875 at Supa burning debt bonds.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

Permanent Settlement (1793) $\Longleftrightarrow$ Revenue Fixed in Perpetuity $\rightarrow$ Sunset Law Auction

Cornwallis Static Colonial Fiscal Extraction Mechanism

Rajmahal Frontier Dialectic $\Longleftrightarrow$ Paharias (Hoe / Shifting Forest Ecology) $\longleftrightarrow$ Santhals (Plough / Damin-i Koh Settled Agriculture)

Colonial Transformation of Forested Tribal Hinterlands

Deccan Crisis Chain $\Longleftrightarrow$ US Civil War Cotton Boom (1861) $\rightarrow$ Slump (1865) $\rightarrow$ Sahukar Debt Bondage $\rightarrow$ 1875 Riots

Global Trade Shock Triggering Rural Peasant Rebellion

Santhal Hool (1855--56) $\Longleftrightarrow$ Sidhu and Kanhu Leadership $\rightarrow$ Creation of Santhal Parganas

First Major Anti-Colonial Tribal Insurgency

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Under the Sunset Law, if the Zamindar failed to pay the fixed revenue installment by sunset of the specified date, his estate was liable to be publicly auctioned immediately.

• **Alert:** Jotedars were much more influential than Zamindars in the villages because Jotedars lived in the village and directly controlled local grain markets, credit, and tenant leases.

• **Alert:** The Deccan Riots Commission Report (1878) was compiled by colonial officials; while rich in eyewitness testimonies, it was biased toward blaming Indian moneylenders rather than extortionate British land revenue demands.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Why did the British introduce the Permanent Settlement in Bengal in 1793? Why did many Zamindars default on payments? [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Reasons for Introduction:** Lord Cornwallis sought a regular, predictable stream of revenue for the East India Company and hoped to create a loyal class of landed gentry who would invest capital in agrarian improvements. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Reasons for Defaults:**
• The initial revenue demand was set excessively high to ensure future company profits.
• Imposed during a period of depressed agricultural prices in the 1790s when ryots could not pay rents. **[1.5 Marks]**

• • Rigid enforcement of the Sunset Law left Zamindars no margin for drought or crop failure. **[1 Mark]**

2. Who were the Jotedars? How did they undermine the authority of the Zamindars in northern Bengal? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Identity:** A class of wealthy peasant cultivators in northern Bengal who acquired immense landed estates (haolas) and controlled local grain trade and moneylending. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Undermining Zamindars:** Unlike absentee Zamindars living in Calcutta, Jotedars lived in the villages; they actively mobilized poor sharecroppers (adhiyars) to delay rent payments to Zamindars and purchased auctioned Zamindari estates. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. Examine the conflict between the Paharias and the Santhals in the Rajmahal hills as a battle between the Hoe and the Plough. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **The Paharias (The Hoe):** Indigenous forest dwellers practicing shifting cultivation; lived on forest produce, gathered mahua, burned charcoal, and defended their independence with bows, symbolized by the hoe. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **The Santhals (The Plough):** Settled peasant cultivators invited by the British from 1800 onwards; cleared heavy forests, reclaimed lowlands, and practiced settled agriculture using the heavy plough. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Displacement:** Colonial authorities designated Damin-i Koh for Santhal settlement; the expanding plough drove the Paharias deeper into barren rocky interiors, disrupting their traditional ecological survival. **[1 Mark]**

4. Discuss the causes and nature of the Deccan Riots of 1875. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Causes:**
• End of the American Civil War (1865) collapsed the cotton export boom, causing raw cotton prices to crash by 50 percent.
• Colonial government simultaneously increased land revenue rates by 50 percent amidst falling prices. **[2 Marks]**

• • Marwari and Gujarati moneylenders (sahukars) refused fresh loans, manipulated debt contracts, and confiscated ryots' land and bullocks. **[1 Mark]**

• **Nature of Revolt:** Began at Supa (Pune district) in May 1875; peasants systematically attacked sahukars' homes, destroyed debt bonds, burnt account books (bahis), and rarely inflicted physical violence. **[1 Mark]**

5. Who led the Santhal Rebellion of 1855-56? What was its major outcome? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Leaders:** Sidhu and Kanhu Santhal. **[1 Mark]**

• **Outcome:** The colonial state carved out a separate administrative district called the 'Santhal Pargana' with special non-regulation protective laws for tribal land. **[1 Mark]**

6. What was the Deccan Riots Commission? State one limitation of its report. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Purpose:** A commission instituted by the Government of India in 1875 to investigate the causes of peasant violence in the Bombay Deccan. **[1 Mark]**

• **Limitation:** Biased toward defending colonial policies, concluding that the rebellion was caused purely by greedy village moneylenders rather than excessive state revenue demands. **[1 Mark]**